

Very Short Videos Are Changing Film Industries

On a film set in China, a 69-year-old actor is playing the part of a wealthy family leader.

In “Grandma’s Moon,” actor Zhu Jian celebrates his birthday with a costly dinner party. And he is about to get a big surprise: One of the workers at the party is his granddaughter.

But there is another big surprise.

“Grandma’s Moon” is not a movie or even a television show. Instead, it is a series of short videos, called a micro drama. Creators shoot them vertically for easy watching on cell phones. Each episode is only minutes long.

Most of the people watching “Grandma’s Moon” are middle-aged workers and retired people. Zhu said that these viewers do not go to movie theaters anymore. He added that it is so easy “...to hold a mobile phone and watch something anytime you want.”

Actor Zhu Jian, 69, rehearses with other actors on the set of a micro drama (or movie) in Zhengzhou, China July 16, 2024. (Reuters/Tingshu Wang)

Micro dramas use story-telling methods like hooks and plot twists to keep millions of viewers watching on their cellphones. And these audiences are very willing to pay for more.

The cliffhangers at the end of each episode are critical to the success of micro dramas. Cliffhangers keep a viewer interested and wanting to watch more. Audiences must pay for the next episode to find out what happened.

Changing the industry

Reuters News Agency reports that China’s micro drama industry is worth \$5 billion. Micro dramas are shot quickly and with little money. The first few episodes are often free. But to watch the whole micro drama series, audiences may have to pay money to watch additional episodes.

Experts say micro dramas are successfully competing with China's film industry.

The micro drama leader is the app Kuaishou. The app is responsible for 60 percent of the top 50 Chinese micro dramas last year. That information comes from Endata, a company that studies media.

Douyin is owned by internet technology company Bytedance, which is also popular with micro drama fans. Other Chinese social media apps like Xiaohongshu and YouTube competitor Bilibili have announced plans to make more.

Micro dramas are now spreading to the United States.

"China discovered this audience first," said Layla Cao, a Chinese producer based in Los Angeles. Hollywood, she says, has not yet.

A director looks at vertical screens on the set of a micro movie during a filming session at a hospital, in Zhengzhou, China, July 17, 2024. (Reuters/Tingshu Wang)

Popular Storylines story-telling techniques

Micro dramas are successful not only for their story-telling methods but also for their interesting plots.

Many popular micro dramas for Chinese audiences are stories about revenge or reaching higher social status. Their popularity is happening at a time when making money and changing your status in China is difficult. Youth unemployment is also high.

The micro dramas often "show people who one day are lower class and the next day become upper class ..." said a 26-year-old screenwriter. Writing under the name Camille Rao, she recently left a low-paid job in the traditional film industry. Now, she writes micro drama stories for American audiences.

Criticisms of micro dramas

China's Communist Party has been critical of micro dramas. Between late 2022 and early 2023, China's regulatory agency, the National Radio and Television Administration, or NRTA, removed 25,300 micro dramas.

In June, the Chinese government began requiring some creators to register micro dramas with the NRTA. The regulator did not answer Reuters' request for comment.

Actor Zhu added that the plot is often unreal or over-the-top; "...so it catches people's attention and a large audience wants to see them," he said.

Zhu said he loves classic films, like "Casablanca." And like many other film lovers working in micro dramas, he thinks they have limited artistic value. He said, "I see it as fast food..."

However, loyal fans of micro dramas disagree.

Huang Siyi is a 28-year-old customer service agent. She enjoys watching romantic micro dramas because "the acting is good and the male and female leads are good-looking."

She adds that it is easy to get hooked on micro dramas.

Actors are on a set of a micro movie filmed at a hospital, in Zhengzhou, China July 17, 2024. (Reuters/Tingshu Wang)

Explosive growth

Micro dramas can be made with little money. The amount of money needed to make them can be between \$28,000 (200,000 yuan) and \$280,000 (2 million yuan), the market research company iResearch reports.

In the central Chinese city of Zhengzhou, creators are making "Grandma's Moon" with not much money and not much time. The show was filmed in just six days.

As micro dramas grow in popularity, actors' earnings have grown too.

Many Chinese micro drama producers have their eye on Western markets.

Micro dramas designed for the West are often made by production and acting crews in Los Angeles and shot on location. The stories are in English and often involve wealth, cheating partners, and miracles.

One of the apps that distributes micro dramas in the West is called LoveShots. In one of its latest micro dramas, a paralyzed woman miraculously regains her ability to walk. Then, she walks in to find her husband cheating on her.

I'm Andrew Smith. And I'm Anna Matteo.

Antoni Slodkowski reported this story for Reuters with additional reporting from Tingshu Wang and Xiaoyu Yin. Anna Matteo adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

vertically -adv. ตรงขึ้นไปหรือทำมุม 90 องศากับพื้นผิวหรือเส้นแนวนอน

episode -n. เหตุการณ์ที่เป็นส่วนหนึ่งของเรื่องราวที่ยาวกว่า หรือของประวัติศาสตร์หรือชีวิต แต่ถูกมองว่าสมบูรณ์ในตัวเอง

hook -n. กลวิธีที่ใช้ดึงดูดความสนใจ โดยเฉพาะในงานดนตรีหรืองานเขียน

plot twist -n. กลวิธีทางวรรณกรรมที่นำเสนอการเปลี่ยนแปลงอย่างรุนแรงในทิศทางหรือผลลัพธ์ที่คาดไม่ถึงของโครงเรื่องในงานวรรณกรรม

audience -n. กลุ่มคนที่ฟังหรือดู (เช่น ที่การแสดงหรือคอนเสิร์ต)

revenge -n. การแก้แค้นเพื่อความผิดที่ได้ทำไปแล้ว

status -n. ตำแหน่งหรือฐานะที่เกี่ยวข้องกับผู้อื่น

screenwriter -n. ผู้เขียนบทและมักจะรวมถึงกำกับฉากของเรื่องราวที่เตรียมไว้สำหรับการผลิตภาพยนตร์

miracle -n. เหตุการณ์มหัศจรรย์ที่ถือเป็นสัญญาณของพลังเหนือธรรมชาติของพระเจ้า

paralyzed -adj. ทำให้ไม่สามารถเคลื่อนไหวหรือกระทำการใดๆ ได้

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. In the micro drama “Grandma’s Moon,” what role does actor Zhu Jian play?

- A. A young man celebrating his birthday.
- B. A wealthy family leader.
- C. A worker at a dinner party.
- D. A detective solving a mystery.

2. According to the article, which of the following best describes a micro drama?

- A. A full-length feature film released in cinemas.
- B. A traditional television series with long episodes.
- C. A series of short videos shot vertically for mobile viewing, with each episode lasting only minutes.
- D. A documentary explaining cultural phenomena in China.

3. Who does actor Zhu Jian identify as the main audience for micro dramas like “Grandma’s Moon”?

- A. Young students and teenagers.
- B. Middle-aged workers and retired people.
- C. Film critics and industry professionals.
- D. International viewers outside of China.

4. How do micro dramas effectively keep viewers watching and encourage them to pay for more content?

- A. By offering all episodes for free to attract a large viewership.
- B. By using complex plotlines that require extensive background knowledge.
- C. By incorporating hooks and critical cliffhangers at the end of episodes, requiring payment for subsequent parts.
- D. By strictly limiting access to only a select group of subscribers.

5. What is the estimated worth of China's micro drama industry, according to Reuters News Agency?

- A. \$5 million.
- B. \$500 million.
- C. \$5 billion.
- D. \$50 billion.

6. Regarding the production and cost model of micro dramas, the article states that they are:

- A. Expensive to produce, with all episodes requiring upfront payment.

- B. Shot quickly with little money, offering initial free episodes before requiring payment for the rest.
- C. Produced by major film studios with large budgets and are entirely free to watch.
- D. Exclusively funded by government grants, making them accessible to all.

7. Which app is identified as the leader in the Chinese micro drama market, responsible for a significant percentage of top dramas?

- A. Douyin.
- B. Xiaohongshu.
- C. Kuaishou.
- D. Bilibili.

8. What observation does Layla Cao, a Chinese producer, make about the expansion of micro dramas to the United States?

- A. Hollywood has fully embraced micro dramas and is now a major producer.
- B. China successfully identified this audience first, while Hollywood has not yet.
- C. Micro dramas have completely failed to gain traction in the American market.
- D. The US market prefers traditional long-form content over short videos.

9. What are two popular themes in Chinese micro dramas, and what societal conditions contribute to their appeal?

- A. Historical epics and scientific discoveries, appealing to a highly educated population.
- B. Revenge and achieving higher social status, popular amidst difficulties in making money and high youth unemployment.
- C. Family dramas and children's education, resonating with stable middle-class families.
- D. International travel and adventure, sought after by affluent global citizens.

10. What career transition did screenwriter Camille Rao make, according to the article?

- A. She moved from writing micro dramas to traditional film scripts due to better pay.
- B. She left a high-paid job in the micro drama industry to pursue classic filmmaking.
- C. She transitioned from a low-paid job in traditional film to writing micro drama stories for American audiences.
- D. She started her own production company for independent short films.

11. What regulatory actions has China's National Radio and Television Administration (NRTA) taken concerning micro dramas?

- A. It has actively promoted micro dramas as a new form of entertainment.
- B. It removed thousands of micro dramas and now requires some creators to register them.

- C. It provided funding to micro drama creators to boost production.
- D. It has issued awards for the most popular micro dramas.

12. How does actor Zhu Jian personally assess the artistic value and typical plots of micro dramas?

- A. He considers them artistic masterpieces comparable to classic films.
- B. He views them as "fast food" with limited artistic value, often featuring unreal or over-the-top plots.
- C. He believes they represent the future of serious dramatic acting.
- D. He states they consistently feature realistic and thought-provoking narratives.

13. What reasons does 28-year-old customer service agent Huang Siyi provide for enjoying romantic micro dramas?

- A. The intricate historical accuracy and educational content.
- B. The high production values and sophisticated cinematography.
- C. The good acting, good-looking leads, and ease of getting hooked.
- D. The deep philosophical discussions and moral dilemmas presented.

14. According to the market research company iResearch, what is the typical cost range for producing a micro drama, and how quickly can they be filmed?

- A. Between \$2.8 million and \$28 million, filmed over several months.
- B. Between \$28,000 and \$280,000, with some filmed in as little as six days.
- C. Less than \$1,000, requiring extensive post-production.
- D. Over \$500,000, with a typical filming schedule of several weeks.

15. What are the distinct characteristics and common storylines of micro dramas specifically designed for Western markets?

- A. They are typically short documentaries focusing on Asian cultural traditions.
- B. They are made by LA crews, in English, and often involve themes like wealth, cheating partners, and miracles.
- C. They strictly adhere to traditional Chinese storytelling, avoiding modern themes.
- D. They are educational programs aimed at teaching English as a second language.